

**Board 1**

North Deals

None Vul

♠ J 10 9 5

♥ 7 5 2

♦ 8 6 4

♣ Q 10 5

♠ 8 6 4

♥ A K 3

♦ K J 10 2

♣ A 8 7



♠ A 7 2

♥ Q J 10 8

♦ 9 5

♣ K J 9 3

♠ K Q 3

♥ 9 6 4

♦ A Q 7 3

♣ 6 4 2

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥Q

contract.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=4 ♣=1 Total = 7

Needing two more winners you will have to make both the ♠K and ♠Q. This will only be possible if East holds the ♠A. Win the first trick (if you don't East might switch to ♣s) and play a small ♠ toward dummy's ♠Q. It holds the trick.

You should take your four ♦ winners now, being sure to end up in your hand. Then play another small ♠ toward dummy's ♠K. This also wins.

You have now won 7 tricks so don't mess around now. Take your two Aces and let them have the last four tricks.

If West held the ♠A you would not have made the

A Simple Finesse has only a 50% success rate. That's why we only take finesses as a last resort.

**Board 2**

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 9 8 6  
 ♥ A K Q J 4  
 ♦ A 7 4  
 ♣ A 2

♠ K J 5 2  
 ♥ 7 5 3  
 ♦ Q 10  
 ♣ K Q 10 5

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
|   | N |   |
| W |   | E |
|   | S |   |

♠ A Q 7  
 ♥ 10 6  
 ♦ 9 8 5 2  
 ♣ 8 6 4 3

♠ 10 4 3  
 ♥ 9 8 2  
 ♦ K J 6 3  
 ♣ J 9 7

| West        | North | East | South |
|-------------|-------|------|-------|
| 1♥          | Pass  | 1NT  | Pass  |
| 3NT         |       |      |       |
| All Pass    |       |      |       |
| 3NT by East |       |      |       |
| Lead: ♦ 3   |       |      |       |

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♦ 3.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=5 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 8

You need just one more winner. Since South probably has 4 ♦s you will not be able to establish a trick in that suit, so your only hope is the ♠Q. You win the first ♦ so they don't get a chance to switch to ♣s, a suit you are worse off in. Then take your 5 ♥ tricks, ending in dummy.

You can't put it off any longer so play a small ♠ from dummy and put the ♠Q on. If it wins you will make your contract, if it loses you won't.

North held the ♠K so you were lucky this time.

But remember, finesses only work half the time. The other half they lose.

**Board 3**

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 10 7  
 ♥ Q J 10 9  
 ♦ J 7 4  
 ♣ 10 6 3

♠ 6 5 3

♥ 8 6 4 2

♦ K 6

♣ K J 5 2



♠ Q J 9 4

♥ 7 5 3

♦ Q 10 9 2

♣ 9 4

♠ K 8 2

♥ A K

♦ A 8 5 3

♣ A Q 8 7

| West         | North | East | South |
|--------------|-------|------|-------|
|              | Pass  | Pass | 2NT   |
| Pass         | 3♣    | Pass | 3♦    |
| Pass         | 3NT   |      |       |
| All Pass     |       |      |       |
| 3NT by South |       |      |       |
| Lead: ♥Q     |       |      |       |

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=4 Total = 8

Needing one more winner you should see right away that it cannot come from ♥s, ♦s, or ♣s. That means you must hope that East has the ♠A. Win the first ♥, then play your 4 ♣ winners ending in dummy.

The moment of truth. You lead a small ♠ from dummy. East plays low and you play the ♠K.

Unfortunately West takes your ♠K with the ♠A. He then plays another ♥ and you at least make 8 tricks but have no hope for a ninth one so you go down 1.

You probably thought since these Deals were all about finesses that they would work all of the time.

Welcome to the real world.

**Board 4**

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A 7 4  
 ♥ K Q J 9 7 5  
 ♦ 8  
 ♣ K Q J

♠ K Q 9 3  
 ♥ 10  
 ♦ K 10 6 5  
 ♣ 10 7 3 2



♠ 8 6 2  
 ♥ 8 4 3 2  
 ♦ A Q 7 4  
 ♣ 9 5

♠ J 10 5  
 ♥ A 6  
 ♦ J 9 3 2  
 ♣ A 8 6 4

| West       | North | East | South |
|------------|-------|------|-------|
| 1♥         | Pass  | 2♥   | Pass  |
| 4♥         |       |      |       |
| All Pass   |       |      |       |
| 4♥ by West |       |      |       |
| Lead: ♠K   |       |      |       |

hand. So you start pulling trumps and establishing the ♣s.

If the ♦ finesse had lost you would have gone down 2 instead of just one.

The risk was worthwhile though since it gave you your only chance of making the contract.

West is to play 4♥. North leads the ♠K.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 4

North found the best opening lead for his side, exposing your ♠ losers before you could establish the ♣ suit for a discard. If you start to pull trumps right away the defense will grab the ♥A, then take their two ♠ tricks and you will still have the ♣A that you cannot avoid.

Other than the ♦A the only useful card in dummy is the ♦Q so you must try to make a winner out of that for a discard. So win the ♠A, lead your singleton ♦ and finesse the ♦Q. Your luck has returned, the ♦Q wins and you discard one of your ♠ losers on the ♦A.

At this point you have not lost any tricks, and you can see that you have only 3 losers remaining in your

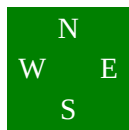
**Board 5**

South Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 6 4  
♥ J 10 5 4  
♦ 9 4 3  
♣ K 7 5 2

♠ K 9 5  
♥ A Q 2  
♦ Q J 10 8 7  
♣ 8 3



♠ 10 8 7 3  
♥ K 8 3  
♦ 6 2  
♣ Q 9 6 4

♠ A Q J 2  
♥ 9 7 6  
♦ A K 5  
♣ A J 10

| West         | North | East | South |
|--------------|-------|------|-------|
|              |       |      | 1 ♣   |
| Pass         | 2NT   | Pass | 6NT   |
| All Pass     |       |      |       |
| 6NT by North |       |      |       |
| Lead: ♠ 3    |       |      |       |

success depends on West holding a specific card, the ♥K.

The double ♣ finesse is much better because its success depends on East holding either of two cards, the ♣Q **OR** the ♣K.

North is to play 6NT. East leads the ♠3.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=1 ♦=5 ♣=1 Total = 11

You need one more winner from the ♥ or ♣ suit. The straight finesse of the ♥K offers a 50% chance of success. The double finesse of the ♣ K Q offers a 75% chance of success. It's a no-brainer. Run 4 ♠s and 5 ♦s ending in your hand. Be very careful not to discard a ♣ from your hand.

Lead a small ♣ and play the ♣10 if East plays low. Let's say West wins the ♣K and returns a ♥.

**DO NOT FINESSE THE ♥.** Stick with your original 75% plan. Take the ♥A and play your small ♣, finessing the ♣J. This is why you couldn't discard a ♣ earlier.

The single ♥ finesse is an inferior play because its

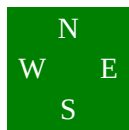
**Board 6**

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 4 3  
 ♥ 7 5 2  
 ♦ A 6 5 3  
 ♣ J 10 9 5

♠ K 7 2  
 ♥ K 9 6 4  
 ♦ 9 2  
 ♣ K 7 6 3



♠ A Q J 10 9 8  
 ♥ A Q J  
 ♦ 8 4  
 ♣ A Q

♠ 6 5  
 ♥ 10 8 3  
 ♦ K Q J 10 7  
 ♣ 8 4 2

| <i>West</i> | <i>North</i> | <i>East</i> | <i>South</i> |
|-------------|--------------|-------------|--------------|
|             |              | 2♣          | Pass         |
| 2♦          | Pass         | 2♠          | Pass         |
| 2NT         | Pass         | 4♠          |              |
| All Pass    |              |             |              |
| 4♠ by East  |              |             |              |
| Lead: ♦K    |              |             |              |

East is to play 4♠. South leads the ♦K.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

South has made another great lead. Any other suit would have given you a free finesse. You should duck the first ♦. It is very possible that South has led from ♦K Q 10 and will be afraid to continue for fear you have the ♦J in your hand. You'd be very happy to see him switch to any other suit. But he doesn't, he continues with the ♦Q which you take with dummy's ♦A.

You are in dummy for the first, last, and only time. You need to try a finesse right now, but which one? At first you might think it makes no difference but, in fact, there is only one reasonable choice. If you finesse the ♠K successfully you may still have a ♠ loser. If you finesse the ♥K successfully you will surely still have a ♥ loser. But if you finesse the ♣K successfully you will eliminate your ♣ loser.

What a great layout! Three possible finesses and every one of them would work.

But as you can see, only the ♣ finesse will actually save you a trick.